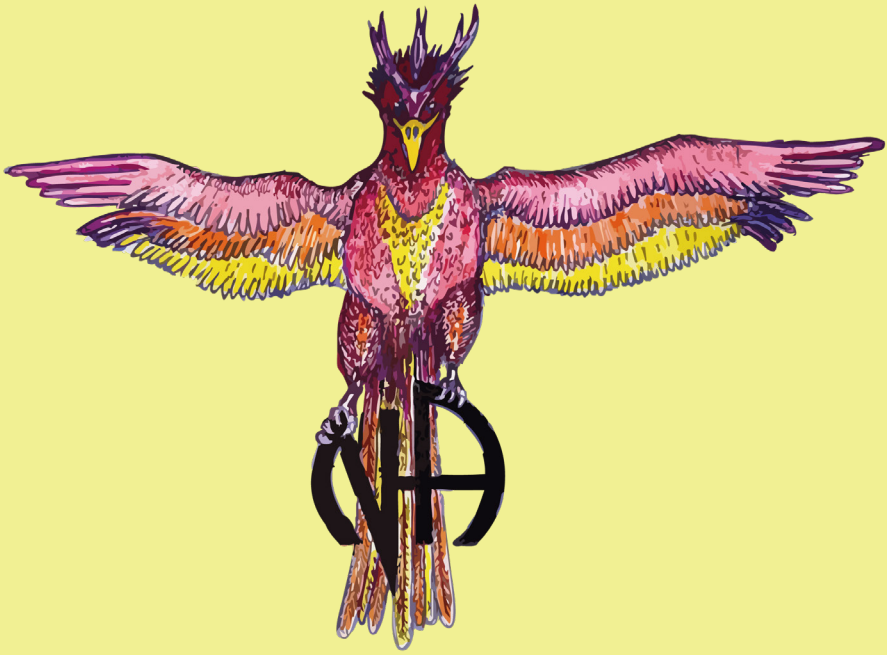
The New/Old

NA Way

EFSC 2025 Edition



Volume 61 - September 2025



The New/Old NA WAY Magazine
Volume 61 - September 2025

This magazine was written in open participation by members of the Groups of The Anonymi Foundation and members of the Groups who participate in the
Fellowship Service Conference and the
European Felloswhip Service Conference

The New/Old NA Way

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My Gratitude Speaks
When I Care
And When I Share
With Others
The NA Way

EFSC Magazine 2025

The following articles in this magazine were written during the European Fellowship Service Conference in The Netherlands.

The Power of the Fellowship - 1

There comes a point in our lives when we come into contact with NA. It can happen in different ways: through a poster, sticker, or flyer at the doctor's office, information handed out at clinics and institutions, or even through friends and family. It doesn't really matter how or through which path—we come into contact with NA.

We start reading about the Fellowship. The term fellowship can give us the impression and the feeling that we are no longer alone, that there is something—a place, a path, a chair—where people come together who all have one thing in common: the disease of addiction.

We also come into contact with literature, meetings, phone calls, writing, and prayer. But also with time before and after the meeting. There are events where service for NA is done, such as translation weekends, the FSC, EFSC, etc.

In all of these things, we can recognize the word fellowship. That first feeling that we are no longer alone, that we stop using drugs and surrender—we can trust that the NA Fellowship is there for us and will take care of us.

All we need is full surrender to the program. At this point, we come into contact with the power of the Fellowship. We are taken along to meetings, translation days/weekends, speaker meetings, the EFSC, etc. All of these things carry us by the strength of the Fellowship. We begin to feel welcome and truly get the sense that we are no longer alone and don't have to do this by ourselves anymore. We now live in the power of the Fellowship.

During meetings, reading literature, or working on the Steps, we come into contact with a power greater than ourselves. We may struggle with this, but just look around you at the meetings—look at the smiles, the glow, the love, the energy, and so on. There is something at work that keeps people clean and gives them a new way of life. Call it God, a Higher Power—if that's still a barrier, call it The Power of the Fellowship.



Keep coming back.

Keep coming back. That's what we hear from the very beginning. Not much later comes the suggestion to do service, and eventually, you work together in a Homegroup. After a life of not being able to hold on to anything, we see that continuing to come back actually works. Maybe it's even become the most normal thing in the world. You stay connected with your fellows, even when the disease is very present.

Working the Steps with your sponsor and applying spiritual principles is not something we do perfectly or consistently. There may still be days, weeks, or even months when we choose our own will and end up in more pain. We keep pushing through, while our conscience—already formed by now—makes it clear that things are only becoming more destructive, and that the solution is just one phone call away.

But by continuing to come back and staying connected, we reconnect again. Maybe it's that key to the meeting place you have, the literature that needs to be laid out, your Homegroup that wants you at Group Conscience, or a fellow who calls to ask how you're doing. These things slow down the insanity, but more importantly, they ease the loneliness and fear we've built back up. And then comes a new opening—not just to stay clean, but to keep recovering.

The Fellowship

A newcomer in the Fellowship. Pretty nerve-wracking, that first EFSC. I know a few people, but really knowing them is something else. Still, I can see and feel the unity—mostly see it. Feeling is still scary. I see the connection and the work that goes into preparing an event like this. The coffee and tea help a lot in building that connection; it feels like a big meeting, only longer and bigger. Just like at my first meeting, that was scary too. Hanging back a bit, testing the waters. But the beautiful thing is, you realize that at events like this, the newcomer is important. Just like at meetings, they are warmly welcomed. I also see the friendships among people who've known each other longer, and that gives me hope for the future. It's amazing to see how much effort people like Bill and the rest of the Fellowship put into building the future of Narcotics Anonymous.



Healing

Can we heal in NA from our sickest patterns? The ones that get worse with every relapse. Will we ever experience freedom from them, or will they always be there, ready to return? One thing is certain: we have a choice! We don't have to react to them anymore. It starts with understanding ourselves through writing. For years, we condemned ourselves for our reactions, fueling our self-hatred. Gaining awareness of why we do what we do brings us a step closer to healing. Setting boundaries and taking space for ourselves starts with facing who we are and how we act. For years, we focused outward, avoiding our own pain. We rationalized situations and denied the reality of who we were. Nothing changed because of that. In the Fellowship, we find hope that we can heal, because others have gone before us. That is the power of the Fellowship.

A Creative Collective

Freedom is often a word and a feeling we lost a long time ago. For years, we were part of everything without ever truly feeling at home. Nodding along, laughing, following, or leading. We did it all, but for many of us, fear and insecurity were the dominant feelings, and freedom was far away.

We, who were once so afraid to ask "stupid questions" or share ideas, all came together. For the first time in a long while, we let down our shields and catch ourselves genuinely laughing, without worrying about what others think. At first, this often doesn't last long, because the disease still wants to rob us of freedom and keep us from joining in. Connection stands in stark contrast to the isolation in which the disease let us wander for so long.

After a while, we start to feel freer—thanks to the love of our Homegroup and the Fellowship. We feel space to ask questions, we are invited and encouraged to participate, and we begin to take an interest in the lives of other NA members and the Fellowship.

This is often the time when our creativity starts to flow, and we break through the barrier of insecurity. For some, this happens quickly, but for many, it takes time. We catch ourselves asking, saying, and writing things we didn't even know we had inside us.

All of this makes connection with others possible—a complete contradiction to life in the grip of the disease. We feel part of something and gain energy from being together with others. We keep learning, and over time, we become an increasingly creative collective.

Meaning

Or rather: the lack of it.

Right now, I don't know where to

find it, and after much thought, I realize this has always been the case. Always moving through life without a real purpose. Elementary school, high school, working, living on my own—doing it all because "that's what you do," because it's normal. Never a sense of what I actually wanted.

Now in recovery, living in the safehouse, I can look ahead to when I'll move back into my own place. And still, there's no sense of meaning—but it's necessary. In recovery, it's the same old story: ask for help, go to the clinic, then the safehouse, aftercare, schema therapy, and meetings. Just going through the motions. Doing things because they're expected. No idea where meaning lies.

The Power of the Fellowship - 2

When I came into NA in 2017, I spent a few years going to meetings, working the Steps, and hanging around. Afterwards, we'd go eat or chat, but I never really felt seen or heard. I drowned in obsession, compulsion, feelings, and thoughts. By 2020, I told myself: I'm done. Same stories, same people, same cliques. I wanted to move forward—focus on school and work. I decided that would be my last meeting.

I was hanging out with a fellow one day, and we were near Venlo. We spontaneously decided to check out a meeting since we were in the area. I saw fellows from years ago, and I was greeted with a hug and a "welcome home, brother." I had never heard that in a meeting before. Then I realized it was an ASIS meeting. People asked how I was doing, genuinely cared, invited me to events, and made me feel welcome. I was seen, heard, and loved for who I was. That, I think, sums it up. The longer I'm part of the Fellowship, the more beautiful it becomes. Fellows become friends, strangers become acquaintances, and what binds us is addiction. When I struggle, I've learned to use the 5 tools through the Fellowship. There are people I can trust with my secrets—something impossible in active addiction. The Fellowship teaches me how to live in the outside world. It teaches me how to live spiritually.

Fear

The fear of not being good enough—that shows up everywhere in my life. Fear of even coming here in the first place, fear of introducing myself, and especially during the meeting. But when I look around me here and share, I notice I'm not alone in this. That gives me the strength and hope to push through, to just do it, to step out of my comfort zone. That's when I really feel the power of the Fellowship.

The Power of the Fellowship - 3

Before and after meetings, and at events, we come into contact with the power of being together. Not being alone is often a huge change for addicts. If we are together but each focused only on our own goals, we miss the strength that Fellowship can create. True fellowship is a group of recovering addicts sharing the same purpose. You experience this when you join a Homegroup, or when you're printing literature together, doing PI service, or traveling together with a newcomer to a meeting. The power of the Fellowship makes it possible for individuals to find recovery with us, so it is important to involve newcomers in the bigger picture.



Coming Home

We found all we needed to do was try.

Try what?

How often did we dismiss help before we even tried? If we didn't know all the answers beforehand, we didn't even start. Fear was a huge factor. Fear of losing control, fear of not getting the life we wanted, fear of everything.

In desperation we stumbled into meetings. There we saw people who did everything to stay clean, who welcomed us home. We, who were too scared for contact, totaly uncomfortable, we felt we came home. We tried more meetings.

We started hearing suggestions, not quite ready to follow them. Full of reservations we tried practicing the first suggestion: keep coming back. We found we wanted what other members had. Their shares gave us hope, we recognized ourselves in them. When finally we could identify as addicts. There was a solution.

We could try the 12 steps, and to do them we needed a sponsor. By practicing we slowly learned to apply spiritual principles, to surrender, open our minds and be honest. It started to work, because we worked it.

We, who were so desperate for help, learned that we could help others. Finally we didn't do it alone anymore. There was a whole fellowship and we became members. Newcomers were hearing our shares

and we made sure they felt welcome, like coming home. Helping them to try, try this life-saving God-given program.

WELCOME HOME!

Freedom from Isolation

Addiction brought us to our knees many times. As much as we wanted to stop and have a normal life, to go through life as normal functioning human beings and enjoy our lives as people seemed to be doing around us, we were not able to cope with life and the things inside of us. Our disease always separated us and wanted us alone. Despite the fact that we felt we wanted to stop, the next day we chose to go back into that isolation. Isolation kept us fully in the grip of our disease.

Once we came to NA, we began to face our disease. It seemed easy to be alone and not have people around us, and when we were alone, we felt in control. Nobody could hurt us then. We discovered that even without drugs, the disease was still present within us, working to get us into isolation again, back to using. When we experienced pain or difficulties in our lives, we noticed that we still had the tendency to isolate ourselves. In NA we hear that an addict alone is in bad company. We go to meetings and surround ourselves with recovering addicts. We call the people we meet there. We participate in our Home Group and spend much of our time with other members in service to NA. The illusion of isolation must be broken.

Our disease made us self-centered, and when that is combined with a closed mind, we believe in our own solutions. We choose to act on obsessions that we think will be the fix to bring us short-lived relief. When we get stuck in our heads and skip the very things we know are good for us, the disease will defeat us. Our old ideas brought us here. Open-mindedness is essential to our recovery. We learn to apply honesty. One way to put this into practice is by writing daily and sharing it with our sponsor. Through consistent action and surrender, we learn to hand over our old, fear-based ideas to the care of God. New ideas begin to come to us.

Surrender in the NA Program

Total surrender to me means accepting I'm not the greatest there is. It means letting go all of me, all of my ideas, my fears and obsessions. Sounds easier than it is, but it starts with being real, getting honest with me and with you. Only then I get help and get in contact with a greater power.

I can't do that by myself, I tried many times and it failed every time. I've had times where I didn't want to get real, I was scared, started lying and did not pick up suggestions.

The result was painful, it became a 'me versus the hostile world' situation again. Even clean I can still practice living by disease rather than principles and it brought me to a low point where I felt like leaving again.

Luckily, my pain motivated me to ask for help again and this time for real cause I knew deep inside I was not gonna make it out clean. This brought me to a deeper level of surrender where theres more honesty.

Today I'm practicing getting real, with myself, my sponsor and in my steps.

Sharing all of me, all the thoughts, ideas and obsessions. It is a freeing experience, it is a new way of life where I don't know the results.

This feels scary and the strength of the fellowship pulls me through.

Seeing others recover, newcomers who come back, taking suggestions from the program and practicing the principles of the steps. It feels more freeing to try something new and it is a great freedom to feel trusted enough to let go of me.



Complete surrender

Should be easy right? Just "live" the principles of NA.

Surrender is in totality and cannot be done without full surrender

Shed a light on the dis-ease

When you think, you're fighting

Fighting only causes pain and suffering

Sometimes we just need to surrender to the small things in life and don't make things complicated

In my hour of need, serenity will help me

I need all the power is gained in the program to quit the fight and ask for help

Letting go of control, accepting reality, deeper inner acceptance.

Sharing your emotions and thoughts so that you alone don't have to carry this weight

Surrender brings peace to life

When I listen, I learn more than when I talk

Some of us did surrender over and over again

I need courage to break through my self centeredness

I have come to admit that I'm not the greatest there is, which opened the door for me once again

When I fall I get up and try again. And again, and again…

The only loss I will lose when I stop the fight, is the loss of ego

Surrender

Surrender gave me the strength to admit I couldn't do it alone and means choosing life.

For some people it seems easier and for some, the fight was longer.

We surrender to one thing and then the next thing shows up

Surrender is not a passive act but an active, conscious choice that comes from trusting that it's impossible to control life itself.

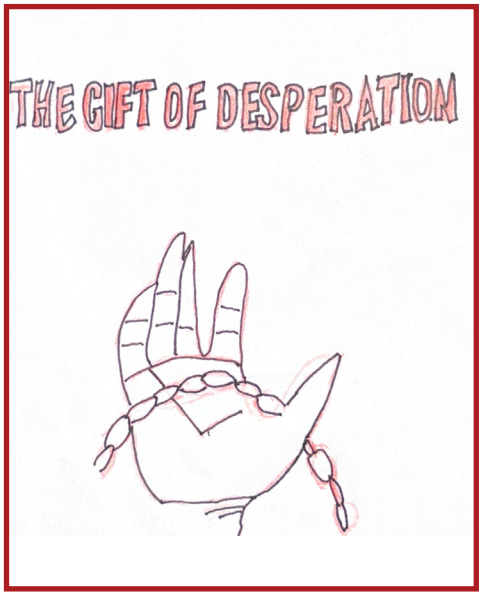
I surrender by not giving up on myself

Surrender to win

When I think I am fighting in the morning the first thing that I do is surrender to win. We need to pray, read and write. That's the first surrender. Because the thinking brings us in the fight and we all know where that leads us. If we surrender we get peace to cope with life. To smile and enjoy the freedom of recovery.

Choosing your path in recovery or addiction; they embody two different realities. Aligning a pathway through decision making. Therefore embodying the results on either side of the spectrum of consciousness. Your body, spirit and mind are important tools which can indicatie important thresholds of resistance and thus structures of growth. Consciousness decision making while cooperating and listening to cues the body gives us are ways of adapting to new patterns in behavior. Any given moment of dis-ease can be seen as an indirect invitation which unfolds to discover a foundation of one's own resilience. Resilience necessary for the hardship that is life. Addiction describes manipulation of outcome. Attained through senses and emotions. We go to extreme lengths and act on whatever the situation asks of us. It incorporates the nervous system, our thought process and muscle memory to promote and manifest a constant state of survival. It has become the new state of existence, infected by outdated illusions accumulated over a lifetime. False stories are mistaken for truth. When the mind adapts to a false narrative it will always be in violating with reality and contradiction becomes a unstable foundation. We are powerless to the results of our inability to align with reality in and of itself.

Surrender means stepping out of your comfort zone and your self-centeredness and connecting with other people. Can't do it alone. Instead it takes courage and bravery and lots of confirmation. The urge to run away from myself roots in my addiction and the inability to cope with reality as is. Especially on social context. Surrendering helps me calm down and get a grip on the situation. It will help me deal with fear to eventually overcome it.



Patience, tolerance, and humility

We didn't arrive in NA with patience and tolerance, and certainly not with humility. We thought we knew it all and could take care of everything ourselves. We wanted instant gratification, wanted things immediately, and it was all about our will. We wanted to control people and reality, refusing to accept how things were. We were insecure, wore masks, and lived in our own bubble. We didn't feel—we thought too much. We discovered our self-centeredness and intolerance; everything came at the expense of others. Drugs seemed to take away our fears and appeared to be a solution for the acceptance we couldn't find, especially for ourselves. We always felt either superior or inferior to others, so we searched for acceptance and approval. Drugs numbed us but solved nothing. We hit rock bottom and had to become open and honest about our disease and its insanity. We had to become patient and surrender. We were reminded we didn't become addicted in just one day, so we needed to take it easy. An opening emerged when we realized we ourselves were the problem in our own lives. Everything felt the opposite in our minds. Addiction was our problem. We live just for today.

By praying daily and admitting our powerlessness over our disease, our patience and tolerance grew. We try to trust that things will work out if we surrender to the program. Where we used to rely on our own solutions before. We learned to look at ourselves, to accept others, and allow them to make mistakes. In the program, we learned about all these principles. We no longer react immediately out of emotions. When we're open to it, life in recovery starts to feel better and more freely. We were able to admit our powerlessness over others, whom we once saw as the problem. Practicing these principles, we progressed further in the steps of NA. Over time, we felt more and more acceptance for life. We became more patient and found acceptance for ourselves, others, and for the world. We see ourselves equal to others. With patience and tolerance, we can handle whatever life brings us; this became reality. We made it a habit to look at ourselves—we, the intolerant and self-centered people. We are part of the solution and of service to others. It will be alright. Acceptance is the key, we heard. It's all good!



IP Concerning Relapse

Recovery: Restoration or return to any former and better state or condition.

Recovery in NA from the disease of addiction is a result of practicing principles in all our affairs.

Recovery happens when we surrender to spiritual principles.

Abstinence does not equal recovery. Recovery is working the steps, finding out who we are, and learning to live. Recovery must be worked on a daily basis or relapse can happen.

The 12 steps help us to experience recovery. We don't use, we call our sponsor regularly, attend meetings daily, have a Home Group, and work Steps in our lives. We are on a path of recovery.

The difference for us between now and then is complete surrender to the process of recovery. We had come to believe that we are addicts with the disease of addiction who must change everything in order to recover. To change we work the 12 Steps and admit that this is about recovery not perfection. We must remain teachable.

Since our early introduction into recovery a lot of questions needed to be answered. Such as, what is recovery and how do you maintain it. The answer is to not participate in any area of our disease. This starts with complete abstinence from all mind- or mood-altering chemicals, including drug replacement therapy medication (DRT's). As we rid ourselves of them, we are able to start a recovery process with the steps.

Remarkable things happen as we start applying Spiritual Principles. Our lives improve as we start facing many self-made obstacles. As we start getting past these obstacles our self-worth grows as does our hope. We find that faith feeds our courage and it no longer matters if it's a mountain or a molehill we are facing. We know in our hearts we can and will move forward no matter what.

We continue to maintain our ongoing recovery by developing a pattern of meetings, steps, sharing and listening. Becoming involved, we begin to feel a part of.

When we stop this process and exert self-will, we begin setting ourselves up for relapse. We don't forget what we had learned; we just wallow in self-pity. Self-will is what almost killed us. Relapse is never an accident. Often others see the signs long before we admit reservations exist in our lives. We find reasons not to go to our regular meetings. We may stop calling the members who know us best. We get angry with the people who love us. In short, we start listening to our addiction, focusing only on the negative.

We became our own Higher Power, our own Group Conscience. Our own everything, the disease was winning. We did everything that we heard in the meetings not to do.

Meeting attendance goes away, spiritual program goes out the door and we're left standing alone again with feelings of emptiness. Once starting the emotional roller coaster, we fall deeper into desperation looking for a way out. When this happens, all avenues generally close and we feel hopeless. Rather than share these thoughts with others we start answering ourselves therefore setting the stage for failure.

Relapse: To fall back into illness after apparent recovery

Just like recovery is a process, relapse is a process.

The mental lapse happens first, it usually begins with "I think…(i.e., I can skip this meeting, I got this, I need to take care of family and job first, those people don't know, get nothing from those meetings….). Then it is followed by the spiritual lapse "I don't…" (i.e., need to pray, work the steps, call my sponsor, share at meetings, do the next right thing, be honest with what I'm feeling) …

The physical relapse (using) i.e. I am, I want, I can, I will) happens last. This is why we need to nurture our spirits with a positive attitude on a daily basis.

When recovery is not our priority, we forget how to live clean and fall back into addictive behaviors, often leading to relapse. We must recover or die. We need to watch people, places and things to guard our recovery to prevent relapse.

When we do not apply the steps in our lives, we are a mess. We stop following through with commitments. Sometimes we never fully surrender. Other times, after surrender and time in recovery, we walk away from the actions and principles that kept us clean.

Relapse is a conscious decision clothed in apathy, complacency and denial. What starts as random thoughts of dissatisfaction and boredom turn into secrecy, self-obsession and an action plan to use. The longer that the internal dialogue stays internal the more we feed oxygen to the fire.

When the question "What if" gets hold of our thought process it begins to take up residence in our heads, ultimately to be answered by "Well, maybe" or "I could just do that". The day comes when "Am I going to use?" is answered by "I don't know". At that point it's only a matter of time before picking up.

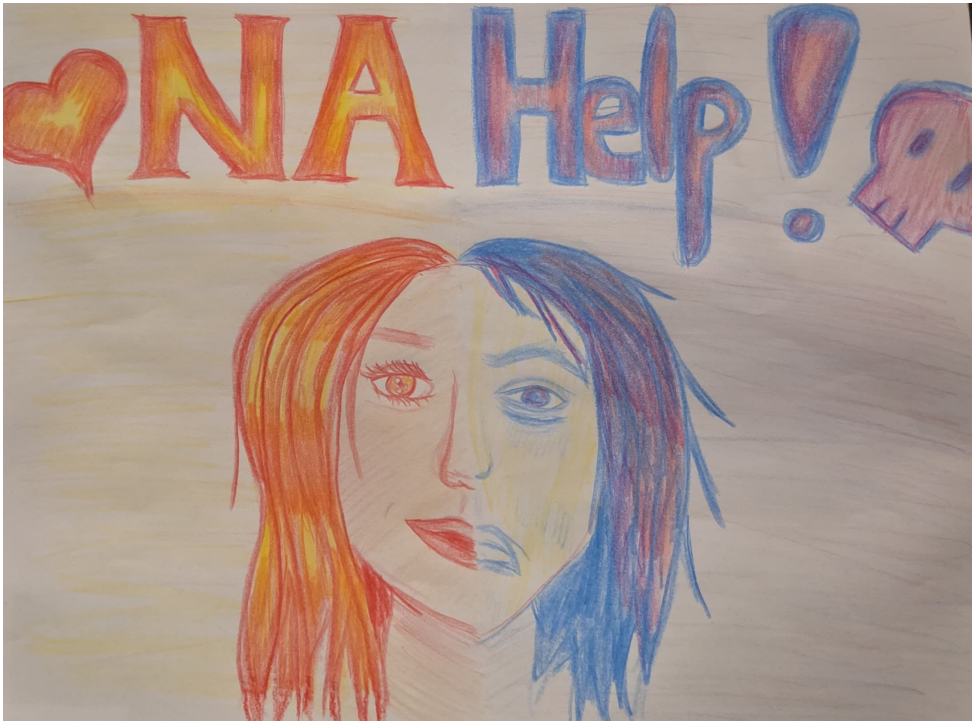
We will either actively seek it out, driving to the dope house or liquor store or the doctor's office, or we put ourselves into a situation we think we can control. Physical or mental pain may also initiate an obsession to use.

People who live this simple program do not relapse. A relapse can be fatal. Relapse brought us to surrender our will and way to God and this program.

Return (Dictionary definition) :o go or come back, as to a former place, position, or state.

Coming back to the rooms of NA after a relapse takes great courage. To regain recovery takes a willingness to change followed by action. We need to accept that if we don't change, we will only repeat the same behavior. We need to honestly look at how we altered our personal program from when we first got clean to when we relapsed. What did we stop doing? What excuses did we tell ourselves? What did we put into our life that was more important than our recovery? Are we now willing to go to any lengths to stay clean?

One day clean is the beginning of hope. Two days clean is the beginning of desire. And three days clean is the beginning of freedom. We often tell ourselves that other members look down on us or dislike us after we relapse. We use this as an excuse to not come back. Yet most members with time have been to enough funerals and would much rather have you in a meeting with a chance to start over. We want you back in our lives. We want you to succeed, but you must be the one to reach out. You must listen to that will to live. After relapse, you may feel like your spirit is broken, that you will never find the passion and joy you first felt in NA.



You may not feel the same way, but you can find a deeper, firmer resolve each day.

When we stopped trying to hide our hurt and finally let people in is when we started to grow again.

When the pain was great enough, we finally surrendered. We have tried every way we could, and it never worked until we fully surrendered.

"We have never seen a person relapse who has thoroughly lived the Narcotics Anonymous Program". *

Our choices boil down to this: Recovery or relapse. "Basic Text"



"Those who are addicted today are more fortunate."

The moment we are introduced to NA we are given a choice, as a result , a chance to recover or die. In this we are fortunate, our fortune resonates into our life and those of others. Our life which was once so wasted now gets a chance to be lived in a loving and caring way. So to say, The NA way. As addicts we are naturally ungrateful and unappreciative, this will not change without some action on our part. Surrendering to the steps and the principles will naturally start this process. Soon we will realise that God holds all power, we get what we need and be rid of the rest. Simple, still not always easy. But with time it will become that, easier. Desirable even. Put the selfwill in the blender, no matter your age, race or gender. When you feel the disease running wild, dont go sleeping. Pick up the phone and get to a meeting. Surrender quietly, move silently.

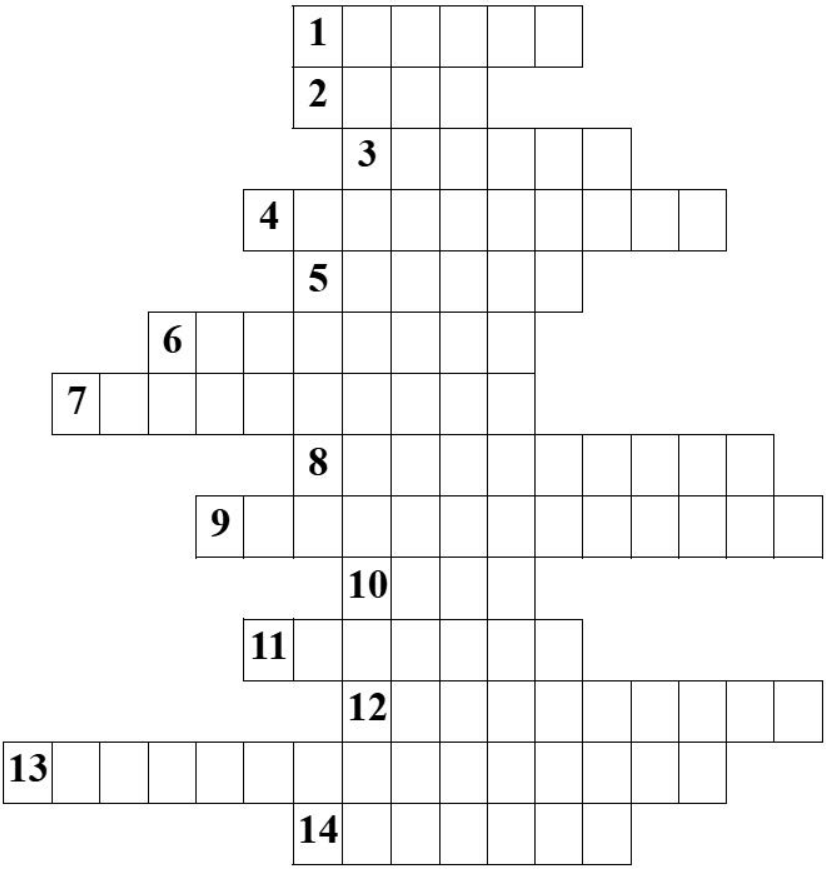
"*In years gone by, very few addicts ever had this last choice." (Greybook Chapter Eight*,)

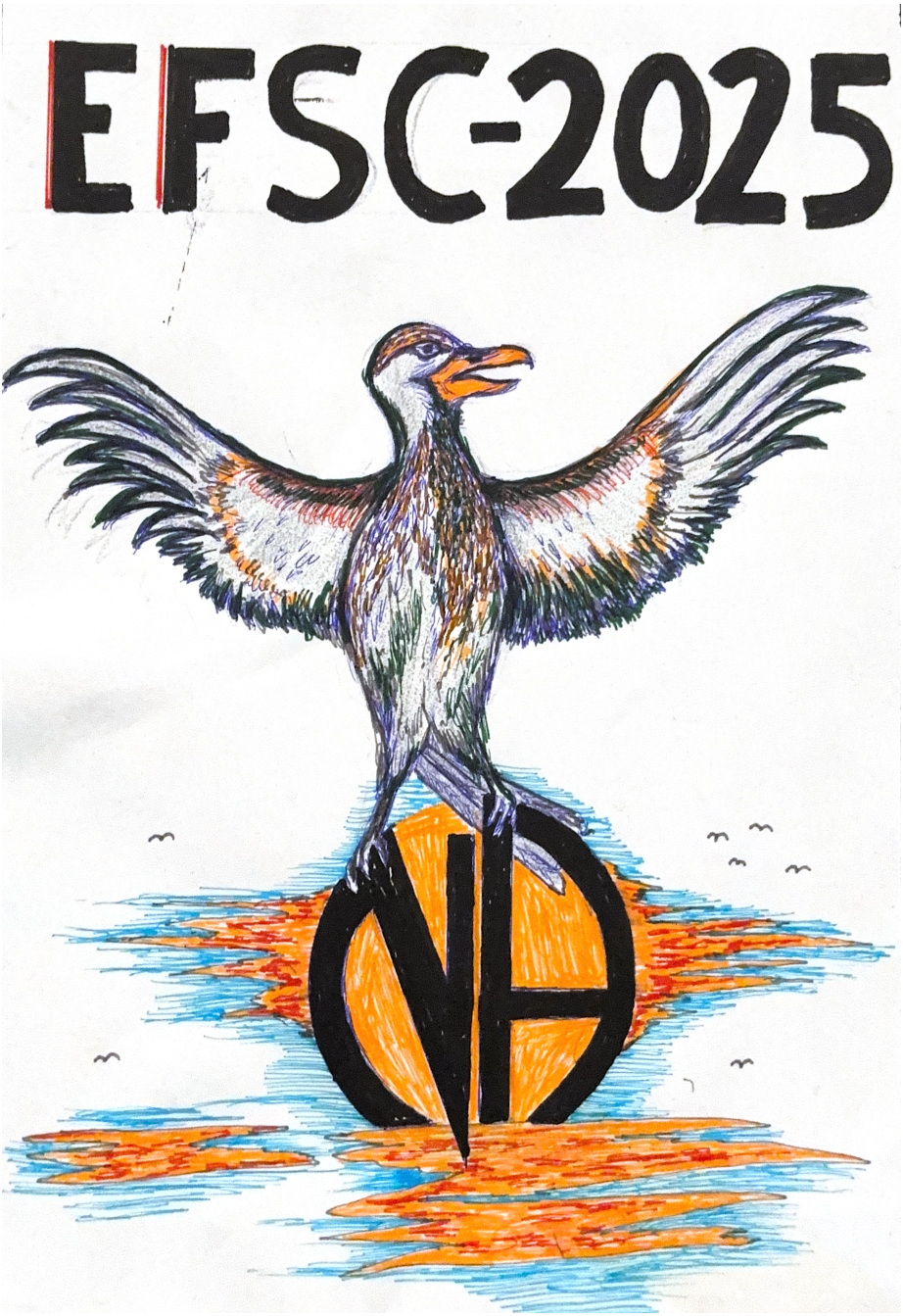
WE DO RECOVER



Puzzle: Filippine

1. To climb a stair you take...
2. Good and orderly direction
3. To repair something
4. A breakthrough
5. ... state of mind
6. Telling the truth
7. Something we can't see
8. An action word
9. Defects of character
10. Edging God Out
11. What we achieve through the Steps
12. Call your sponsor
13. Embracing all parts of yourself
14. Progress of adapting the Program




EFSC-2025

Upcoming Events

20th Annual Fellowship Service Conference for N.A.
Date: June 26th thru June 28th, 2026
Hamburg, PA

EFSC NETHERLANDS
Date: September 10th thru 13th , 2026
Ambt Delden, The Netherlands

Your event here? Send information to info@nahelp.org



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Please send your articles, event information, comics or other input to:

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Your Fellowship Magazine
Share... and be shared with..

Like it was when NA was new and young and life or death intense:
You matter to us so we will tell you the truth as we know it with nothing held back.

THE NEW/OLD NA WAY

"... so that no addict seeking recovery need ever die..."
We publish your input -- the opinions presented are not necessarily those of the New/Old NA Way or Anonymi Foundation